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Environment Design

Make the right choice the easy one: a free quick start

FREE QUICK START

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FREE QUICK START

Start here

This is the free quick start of Environment Design. It covers why the setup beats willpower, friction, your kitchen, the ADHD version and a 30-day audit. The complete guide adds bedroom, digital and social environments, commitment devices and worksheets.

The complete guide

The full edition is $9.90 with 5 complete guides, in PDF, with a 15 day refund. adrianonutrition.com/guides

CHAPTER 1

It is not you, it is the setup

We blame character and ignore the situation

Psychologists have long documented that people explain behavior by character and underestimate the role of the situation. Lee Ross called it the **fundamental attribution error.**[1] When you skip the gym you think "I am lazy." You rarely think "my gym bag was in the trunk of a car I did not take, the route had traffic, and I had no plan for when I was tired." Seeing the situation is the first step to changing it.

The willpower tank is a weak foundation

A popular explanation says self-control is a tank that empties with use. That idea, called ego depletion, was one of the most famous findings in psychology. It has not held up. A 23-laboratory preregistered replication with 2,141 participants found an effect of d = 0.04, which is statistically indistinguishable from zero,[2] and a later project with 36 laboratories found d = 0.06.[3] Researchers still debate why, but you should not build your life on a tank that may not exist.

What this means for you

If the willpower story is shaky, then the useful question is not "How do I get more discipline?" It is "What does my environment make easy, and is that what I want?"

Habits are tied to place

A habit is a behavior cued by context, so changing the context changes the habit. In a study of students transferring to a new university, their exercise, newspaper reading and TV watching habits **survived the move only when the context stayed similar** (for example, reading the paper with the same people). When the context changed, the habits broke down and behavior followed current intentions again.[4] Reviews by Wendy Wood and colleagues reach the same conclusion: habits are triggered by cues, and altering the cues is one of the most reliable levers we have.[5]

CHAPTER 2

Friction: make it easy or hard

Friction is the effort between you and an action. High friction makes an action less likely. Low friction makes it more likely. Apps are built to remove friction (one-tap buying, autoplay). You can do the same in reverse.

What the evidence says

A Cochrane systematic review of 24 randomized trials looked at changing how **available** or how **close** food is. Having fewer options available lowered selection of the targeted food, and placing food farther away reduced how much people ate (SMD -0.60 across 15 comparisons, 1,098 people). The authors rated the certainty as **low or very low**, and the studies were mostly small laboratory experiments with snack foods.[6] So the direction is consistent, and the exact size is uncertain.

About some viral numbers

You may have seen statistics like "candy in a clear bowl gets eaten 66% more" or "food at eye level is eaten twice as much." Many of these come from a Cornell food lab, and several of that lab's papers were later retracted or corrected. I do not use those numbers. The trend (closer and more visible means more eaten) is supported by the independent trials above, but not the precise figures.

The friction ladder

To do LESS of something	To do MORE of something

Remove it (do not buy it, delete the app)	**Pre-load it** (clothes laid out, bag packed, food prepped)
Put it far away (top shelf, basement, other room)	**Put it close** (counter, desk, front door)
Make it a hassle (opaque container, log out, remove saved card)	**Make it visible** (clear container, book on the pillow)
Make it slower (wait 10 minutes, ask a friend first)	**Make it automatic** (alarm, default, recurring order)

Use the strongest step you can live with. If you can stop buying the thing, that beats hiding it. If you cannot, move it up the ladder one step.

The seconds test

Count the seconds between you and each behavior. Your aim: the behavior you want is a few seconds away and the one you do not want is at least a minute away. This is my practical rule of thumb from coaching, not a laboratory threshold. It is useful because it turns a vague idea into something you can measure and fix.

CHAPTER 3

Kitchen architecture

The kitchen is the highest-leverage room for most nutrition goals, because it is where decisions about food actually get made, usually when you are hungry and tired.

Arrange by how often you want to reach for it

Zone	Put here
Eye level and the front of the fridge	Washed, cut vegetables and fruit in clear containers. Ready protein: boiled eggs, Greek yogurt, cooked chicken, hummus.
Counter	Fruit bowl. Water bottle. Your supplements, if you use any, next to where you eat breakfast.
Waist level	Rice, oats, beans, canned fish, nuts in a portion-sized container.

High shelves, back of the pantry	Anything you are trying to eat less of. Snacks, sweets, alcohol, if you keep them at all.

Portion and tableware size

A Cochrane review of 72 studies found a small to moderate effect: people **consistently eat more when they are served larger portions, packages or tableware.** The estimate was that a sustained reduction in exposure to large sizes across a whole diet could cut about 144 to 228 kcal per day, with moderate-quality evidence for portions and weaker evidence for plate size specifically.[7] So smaller portions help. Do not expect a smaller plate alone to transform your results.

Shop the environment, not the willpower

- **Shop with a list and after a meal.** Never when hungry.
- **Do not buy your trigger foods.** The best moment to resist is in the store, once, not at 9 PM ten times.
- **Buy single servings** of the foods you overeat, if you buy them at all.
- **Keep a default meal at home.** Eggs, rice, frozen vegetables. When life is messy you are never starting from zero.

Kitchen audit (15 minutes)

Open the fridge and the pantry. Write down what you see first. Move one healthy thing to eye level and one trigger food out of sight. Photograph it. Look again in a week.

CHAPTER 4

Environment design for ADHD

With ADHD, what is out of sight is often out of mind. That is a problem when your good habits are hidden, and a tool when your bad habits are. The principles below come from my own practice and my coaching, not from trials, so test them.

1. **Make good cues loud and bad cues invisible.** Put the water bottle on the keyboard. Put the chips in a cupboard you do not open.

2. **Create a landing strip.** One spot by the door for keys, wallet, bag, gym clothes and the thing you must not forget tomorrow. If it is not on the strip, it does not exist.
3. **Use physical timers and alarms,** not only your phone. A kitchen timer does not come with notifications.
4. **Use a wall calendar or whiteboard** where you walk past it every day.
5. **One purpose per place.** The desk is for work, the bed for sleep. If you work on the couch and scroll at the desk, your brain gets mixed signals.
6. **Try body doubling:** work next to someone, in person or online. It is popular in the ADHD community and many people find it helpful, but formal research is still limited.
7. **Reduce choice.** The fewer things on the surface, the fewer things to distract you.

Be kind to your future self

If your space gets messy again, that is not failure, it is data. Ask what made it hard to keep and adjust the system. Do not blame yourself.

CHAPTER 5

The 30-day environment audit

Week	Goal	What to do
1	**Observe**	Track every time the behavior happens, with the cue: what you saw, where, who, how you felt.
2	**Remove**	Eliminate the most obvious cues. Where you cannot, add friction.
3	**Replace**	Add visible cues for the new behavior and take friction out of it.
4	**Refine**	Look at what changed. Keep what works. Fix one thing that did not.

Your first seven days

Redesigning everything is overwhelming. One room is not.

Day	Task
1	Pick ONE behavior to change and name the room where it most often happens.

2	Audit that room: what is at eye level, within reach, visible from the doorway?
3	Remove or hide cues for the behavior you do not want. Do not add anything yet.
4	Add ONE visible cue for the behavior you do want, where the old cue used to be.
5	Do the same for your phone: notifications, home screen.
6	Write one if-then plan for your hardest situation.
7	Review without judgment. Pick the next room.

Want more? The complete guide has every chapter, worksheets and the full reference list. adrianonutrition.com/guides

Questions?

Send me a DM on Instagram: @adriano.nutrition. I read every message.

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